Commission shields e-SAF ahead of ReFuelEU revision

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【要点】

・欧州委員会は航空業界による合成燃料（e-SAF）目標の緩和要求を拒否し、2030年から0.7%の最低義務水準を維持する方針を示した。

・ReFuelEU規制の改正は技術的な簡素化に限定され、目標の野心的レベルは変更しないと委員会は明言した。

・目標未達時の罰金は燃料供給業者に適用されるが、航空会社はその多大な費用が自社に転嫁される可能性を懸念している。

・航空業界がe-HEFA（グリーン水素由来のSAF）をe-SAF義務に含めるよう要求しているが、委員会は慎重な姿勢を示している。

【メール原文】

Presented by BMW Group By JORDYN DAHL with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — The European Commission rejected the airline sector's push to

Presented by BMW Group

By JORDYN DAHL

with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO

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SNEAK PEEK

— The European Commission rejected the airline sector’s push to weaken ReFuelEU targets for synthetic fuels and defended its proposal to expand the ETS to non-EU destinations.

— The U.S. is proposing penalties against Spanish shipping after concluding that Madrid created “unfavorable shipping conditions” by denying U.S.-flagged vessels access to Spanish ports in 2024.

— Europe’s car lobby is urging policymakers to come to a negotiated compromise on the IAA and emission targets for automakers — and fast.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

DRIVING THE DAY

COMMISSION REJECTS AIRLINES' CALL TO DILUTE E-SAF TARGETS: The Commission ruled out postponing or scrapping the mandate for synthetic sustainable aviation fuel (e-SAF) in next year's revision of the ReFuelEU Aviation regulation, a senior official said on Wednesday. However, the executive signaled caution over a proposal to broaden the definition of synthetic fuels to include certain types of SAF made from used cooking oil.

Airline lobbies IATA and A4E are pushing for changes to the e-SAF mandate amid concerns that fuel producers will not be able to supply sufficient volumes.

Forget about it: Next year's review of ReFuelEU, which requires airlines and fuel suppliers to increase the use of SAF to cut emissions, offers an opportunity to amend the legislation. But according to Eddy Liegeois, head of aviation policy at DG MOVE, the Commission intends to limit changes "to simplify the rules … and some technical amendments," he said at an IATA conference Wednesday. "We will not modify the level of ambitions of the target," he added, referring to the minimum 0.7 percent share of e-SAF that will be required in aviation fuel supplied from 2030.

Fines for e-SAF gaps: "Penalties are part of the scheme," he said, spelling out the Commission's position on the consequences of missing the targets. Although ReFuelEU penalties would fall on fuel suppliers failing to meet the mandate, airlines fear that the multibillion-euro costs could be passed on to them.

Genuine synthetic: Another request from airline lobbies also received a cold response from the senior Commission official. The International Air Transport Association is pushing for SAF produced using green hydrogen — so-called e-HEFA — to count toward the e-SAF mandate. The IATA position is also backed by some producers of SAF from used cooking oil.

This idea "is something that we are analyzing with our colleagues from DG Energy," Liegeois said. But, he added, any broadening of the e-SAF definition should not undermine investment in "genuine" synthetic fuel production, a fear already raised by e-SAF producers, worried that e-HEFA could satisfy part of the e-SAF quota without creating new synthetic-fuel capacity, slowing the growth of the SAF industry.

Tough crowd: Airlines are also lobbying against the proposed extension of the Emissions Trading System. It currently applies to flights within the EU, but the Commission wants to extend it to flights departing the EU for Middle Eastern hubs. Carriers prefer the U.N.'s Carbon Offsetting and Reduction Scheme for International Aviation over the more expensive ETS.

Brussels cool on CORSIA: "CORSIA is and remains the only global market-based measure" to tackle emissions, Liegeois said. "But CORSIA should also deliver," he added. "We expect to see concrete commitments in the next phase" of the U.N. scheme, noting that the EU plans to reassess the situation in 2032, potentially reopening the debate over the geographical scope of the ETS.

Who pays the bill? IATA did not immediately respond to Liegeois' remarks. But recent statements from airlines show that the cumulative cost of EU climate policies is becoming a major concern for the sector. According to new research by BloombergNEF seen by Tommaso, the global airline industry could face around $50 billion in annual environmental compliance costs by 2035 under the announced policies.

MARITIME

US EYES PORT FEES ON SPANISH SHIPS: The U.S. Federal Maritime Commission is proposing penalties against Spanish shipping after concluding that Madrid created “unfavorable shipping conditions” by denying some U.S.-flagged vessels access to Spanish ports in 2024.

How we got here: The dispute dates back to late 2024, when Spain blocked two U.S.-flagged vessels from calling at its ports under a policy restricting ships suspected of carrying military supplies to Israel. The FMC opened an investigation that December into whether those denials discriminated against U.S. shipping.

Now the retaliation: The regulator said on Wednesday evening its investigation confirmed unfavorable treatment of U.S.-flagged shipping and is proposing a $200,000 fee per voyage on all Spanish-flagged vessels, alongside possible restrictions on imports of Spanish products including perfumes and cosmetics, oils and fats, ceramics, stone products, and sugar and confectionery.

Reminder: A similar process played out with China in 2025, when the U.S. trade representative moved to impose per-voyage fees on Chinese vessel operators and on operators using Chinese-built ships, arguing Beijing’s dominance of shipbuilding and maritime logistics was hurting U.S. commerce and weakening domestic shipbuilding. That regime was later suspended for one year from Nov. 10, 2025, after a U.S.-China trade deal, while Washington continued negotiations over the underlying maritime and shipbuilding dispute.

Not final yet: The FMC is seeking public comments before deciding on the remedy and will offer Spain a hearing.

A message from BMW Group: The debate between electrification and renewable fuels should not be binary. We can use multiple technologies to cut emissions, strengthen resilience and give consumers choice. In this Q&A , Dr. Frank Niederländer of BMW Group explains how renewable fuels can complement Europe’s growing electric vehicle market.

TRANSPORT BUDGET

TRANSPORT INDUSTRY MAKES LAST-MINUTE BUDGET PLEA: Europe’s transport sector is warning EU leaders not to make infrastructure pay in the next EU budget deal, after Ireland’s latest compromise cut the Connecting Europe Facility’s transport envelope by 11% compared with the Commission proposal.

The timing: In a joint letter to EU heads of state and government as they gather for the European Council today, a broad coalition spanning rail, roads, ports, aviation, logistics and public transport argues that transport has taken a bigger hit than the 8% cut applied to the overall budget proposal. The group says the revised CEF would leave transport with just 2.5% of the EU budget and less than €4 billion a year for civilian infrastructure across the 27 member countries. It warns that cuts risk leaving missing TEN-T links unfinished and putting the 2030 and 2040 network deadlines further out of reach.

The ask: The signatories want leaders to restore CEF transport funding at least to the Commission’s proposed level, ring-fence a minimum transport share inside the new national and regional spending plans, and explicitly open the European Competitiveness Fund to transport as an additional source of money rather than a replacement for dedicated infrastructure funding.

Follow our European Council live blog here for the latest updates.

CARS

CAR LOBBY URGES SPEED ON AUTO PACKAGE: EU car lobby ACEA has a clear message for policymakers negotiating the automotive package: Get a move on. The group wants the package to be finalized early next year, which would require lawmakers to come to an agreement by the end of this year on the Industrial Accelerator Act and the emission targets for automakers.

But one we like: The lobby and individual car manufacturers have pushed hard for more flexibilities in the emission standards they must reach or face fines. “Let me make it clear that draconian penalties have never been something we think is a good idea,” Mercedes-Benz CEO and ACEA President Ola Källenius said. ACEA wants emissions to be judged across five years instead of the proposed three and the ability to bank credits if an automaker outperforms the standards.

“Made in Europe” scope: The lobby also wants the U.K. to be included as “Made in Europe” in the IAA. For neighboring countries where several automakers and suppliers have production — like Turkey and Morocco — ACEA proposes that existing facilities be grandfathered in. (Read more about their position here, which POLITICO scooped in September.)

Turkey’s troubles: Turkey is continuing its lobbying blitz around Brussels, with Kemal Yazici, the chairman of the Turkish Automotive Industry Exporters Association, meeting with MEPs and other stakeholders to continue pushing for the country to be counted as “Made in Europe.” “We should be equal to EU 27 in the automotive industry perspective. That is our request,” Yazici told Jordyn in an interview on Wednesday.

French-German deal: Yazici is also meeting with policymakers in Paris and Berlin while they negotiate a joint stance on the IAA and CO2 standards. He’s not the only one. Källenius, too, said the lobby has been in discussions with Paris and Berlin. ACEA is providing the capitals with “insight into what we think is the best game plan,” he said, adding that “it’s a good thing” if the EU’s biggest capitals present a common position at the Council.

Status update: Both capitals wanted to get their bargain settled in time for today’s European Council. French President Emmanuel Macron said earlier this week that the deal was “imminent,” but one has failed to materialize. Berlin is set on getting concessions on the CO2 standards, while Paris wants to get the IAA over the line with a more stringent definition of who qualifies as “Made in Europe.”

U-TURN, PLEASE: The German Unions DGB, IG Metall and IGBCE are pressing the government to change course and back stricter EU-first rules in the IAA. Germany’s latest non-paper on the issue is “worrying,” they write in a letter to the chancellery obtained by our colleague Frida Preuß (available here in German).

PIT STOPS

From us : Deadly drone strikes in Bulgarian and Romanian waters are turning the Black Sea war into a wider European shipping problem.

From us : Portugal’s government has chosen Lufthansa over Air France-KLM to become a major shareholder in TAP Air Portugal.

European Shipowners says the EU’s proposed shipping decarbonization fund is only one-third of what is needed, calling for 330 million ETS allowances instead of 110 million.

**A message from BMW Group: Europe’s automotive industry is entering a crucial decade. As manufacturers navigate electrification, global competition, geopolitical uncertainty and rising energy

costs, Europe faces the challenge of delivering decarbonization while strengthening competitiveness and resilience. In this Q&A , OLITICO Studio speaks to Dr. Frank Niederländer, Vice President for Government Affairs Europe at BMW Group, about the choices and conditions that will shape the next phase of Europe's automotive transition. He discusses how Europe can strengthen the industrial base behind the transition, what it will take to build a competitive battery ecosystem and why establishing new capabilities requires the right investment conditions — and time to scale. He also explores why we should look beyond tailpipe emissions to consider the full value chain, and the potential role of renewable fuels alongside electrification. And why the transition will only succeed if it works for consumers and businesses while keeping investment, innovation and value creation in Europe.**

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

US weighs $200,000 fine on Spanish vessels following Israel cargo ban
The Federal Maritime Commission found the government of Socialist Pedro Sánchez was responsible for unfavorable shipping conditions.
By Stefanie Bolzen · Oct 14, 2026, 09:29 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

How to watch the EU leaders' summit like a pro
From China to energy prices, EU leaders face two days of political firefighting. Here's what to look out for.
By Gerardo Fortuna · Oct 14, 2026, 06:41 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Deadly drone strikes in NATO waters raise stakes for Black Sea trade
After numerous lethal drone attacks in NATO waters, Black Sea countries seek alliance support and EU leaders discuss how to restore safe passage.
By Martina Sapio, Victor Jack, Agnes Rønberg · Oct 14, 2026, 05:27 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

EU research chief slams reduced budget proposal as 'strategic mistake'
The Irish had pitched a smaller research budget than the Commission proposal.
By Pieter Haeck · Oct 14, 2026, 04:36 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Lufthansa beats Air France-KLM in bid for TAP stake
By Tommaso Lecca · Oct 14, 2026, 04:27 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

EU-China trade progress welcomed, yet trust issues linger
While a deal to reduce exports of hybrid vehicles represents an early win, tougher issues remain on the negotiating table.
By Francesca Micheletti, Koen Verhelst · Oct 14, 2026, 02:27 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

India's Modi to visit Brussels as trade deal signing beckons
By Camille Gijs · Oct 14, 2026, 02:02 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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